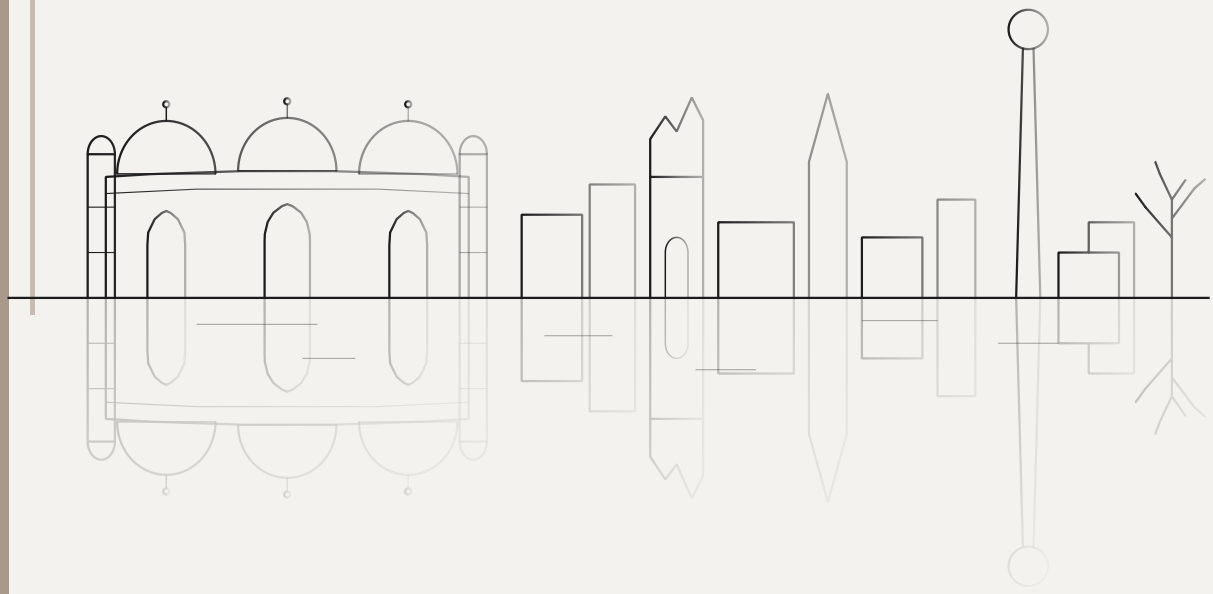


PORTFOLIO

Architecture & Cultural Heritage

Priyati Golder

2018 – 2025

SELECTED WORKS

HALLE (SAALE), GERMANY

INTRODUCTION

Priyati Golder

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For me, architecture begins with people and place.

I see every project as a conversation between the people who will use a space, the character of its site, and the possibilities of material and light. Good architecture, I believe, does not need to shout; it quietly supports everyday life and is built to last.

I work across scales, from the detail of a joint to the shape of a neighbourhood, moving between sketches, drawings and models to test ideas. Research and close observation of context are part of how I design, not separate from it.

I value buildings that are honest in their construction, responsive to climate and culture, and open to change over time. This portfolio presents a selection of projects that reflect this way of thinking.

SELECTED WORKS

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IMAGE

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Church Redesign

A sacred space, reimagined

PROJECT	Academic · Master's Studio
MENTOR	Prof. Dr. Rudolf Lückmann
YEAR	2024
LOCATION	St. Bartholomäi, Zerbst, Saxony-Anhalt, Germany

This project transforms St. Bartholomäi in Zerbst into a place that serves both worship and community life. Inside the historic walls, a new timber structure inspired by the form of trees creates an open, light-filled interior, without touching the historic fabric.

CONTEXT

At the heart of Zerbst, the ruined nave of St. Bartholomäi stands open to the sky, while the town lacks shared places where people can meet. The project brings these two together: the task was to design within this historic setting, respecting its character while giving the church a new role in everyday community life.

CONCEPT

The building is conceived as both a place of worship and a welcoming, inclusive space for the whole community. Its programme follows three rhythms of use:

Daily	Prayer, community library, co-working and coffee shop
Weekly	Sunday worship, after-school programmes, community classes in arts and parenting, and support groups
Seasonal	Holiday markets and youth camps

DESIGN

The key principle was to add new structure without touching the old. A free-standing timber structure, shaped like branching trees, rises inside the historic walls and carries a new roof, recalling the rhythm of Gothic vaults in a contemporary material. The altar is moved to the centre of the nave so the space gathers around it. A new upper floor houses a community library, a quiet place for reading above the busy gathering space below. A ramp connects the two levels, making the whole building universally accessible, while kitchen and toilets sit at the sides to keep the central space open.



02 Aerial view: St. Bartholomäi within the historic town centre of Zerbst

Existing Condition

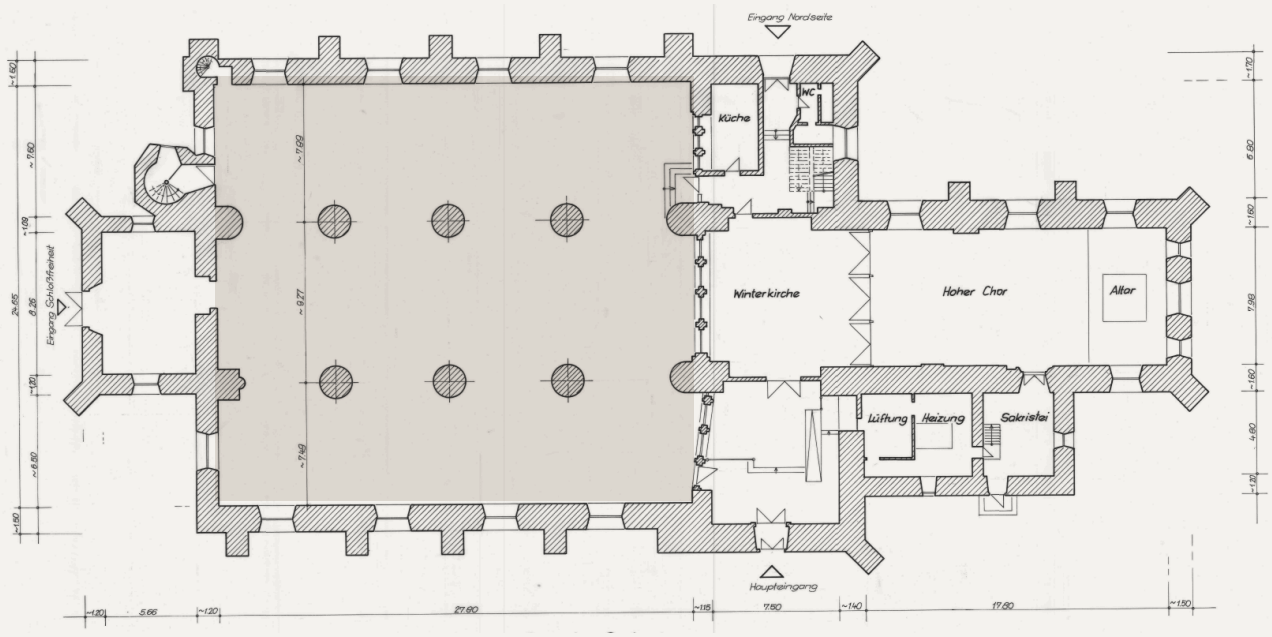
A roofless nave in the heart of Zerbst

HISTORY

St. Bartholomäi was badly damaged during the Second World War. While the choir was later repaired and is still used as the winter church, the nave remains a roofless ruin. This open nave is the space where the new intervention takes place, inside the ruin, without touching its historic fabric.

TODAY

Six round brick columns still carry the pointed arcades that once divided the nave into three aisles. The outer walls, built of brick and fieldstone, stand to their full height with their tall pointed windows, and the massive west wall closes the space. Without a roof, the nave has become an open, paved courtyard: impressive in scale, but exposed to the weather and without a roof to shelter everyday use.



EXISTING PLAN The roofless nave (shaded), with the repaired winter church (Winterkirche) and high choir (Hoher Chor) to the east.



01



02



03

01 The roofless nave looking west: six brick columns and pointed arcades, open to the sky.

02 The fieldstone west wall, seen between the arcades.

03 The repaired eastern part with its large glazed openings, seen from the ruined nave.

The Timber Structure

A forest inside the ruin

IDEA

The new structure is inspired by the form of a tree. Each timber column rises from the floor of the nave like a trunk and divides into branches beneath the roof. Placed in rows that follow the line of the existing columns, these "trees" form a forest inside the historic walls, an organic counterpart to the heavy masonry of the ruin.

FORM

At the top, curved timber ribs branch outwards like a crown. The ribs of neighbouring trees cross and overlap, forming a canopy of pointed arches that recalls the Gothic vaults that once covered the nave. Rather than copying the lost vaults in stone, the design reinterprets them in a contemporary material, so the memory of the original space is felt without being imitated.

MATERIAL

Timber was chosen because it is sustainable, renewable and traditional. It stores carbon and has been used in building in this region for centuries. Its warmth contrasts clearly with the brick and stone of the church. All members share the same cross-section of 50 × 50 cm, built up from thin bonded layers of wood, which allows them to be bent into curves while staying strong enough to span the nave.

STRUCTURE

The timber trees carry the new roof above the historic walls. Curved brackets branch out from the trunks to support the gallery floors of the community library, and a ramp connects both levels for universal access. All loads travel through the trunks down to their own foundations, so the old walls carry no new loads.

OLD AND NEW

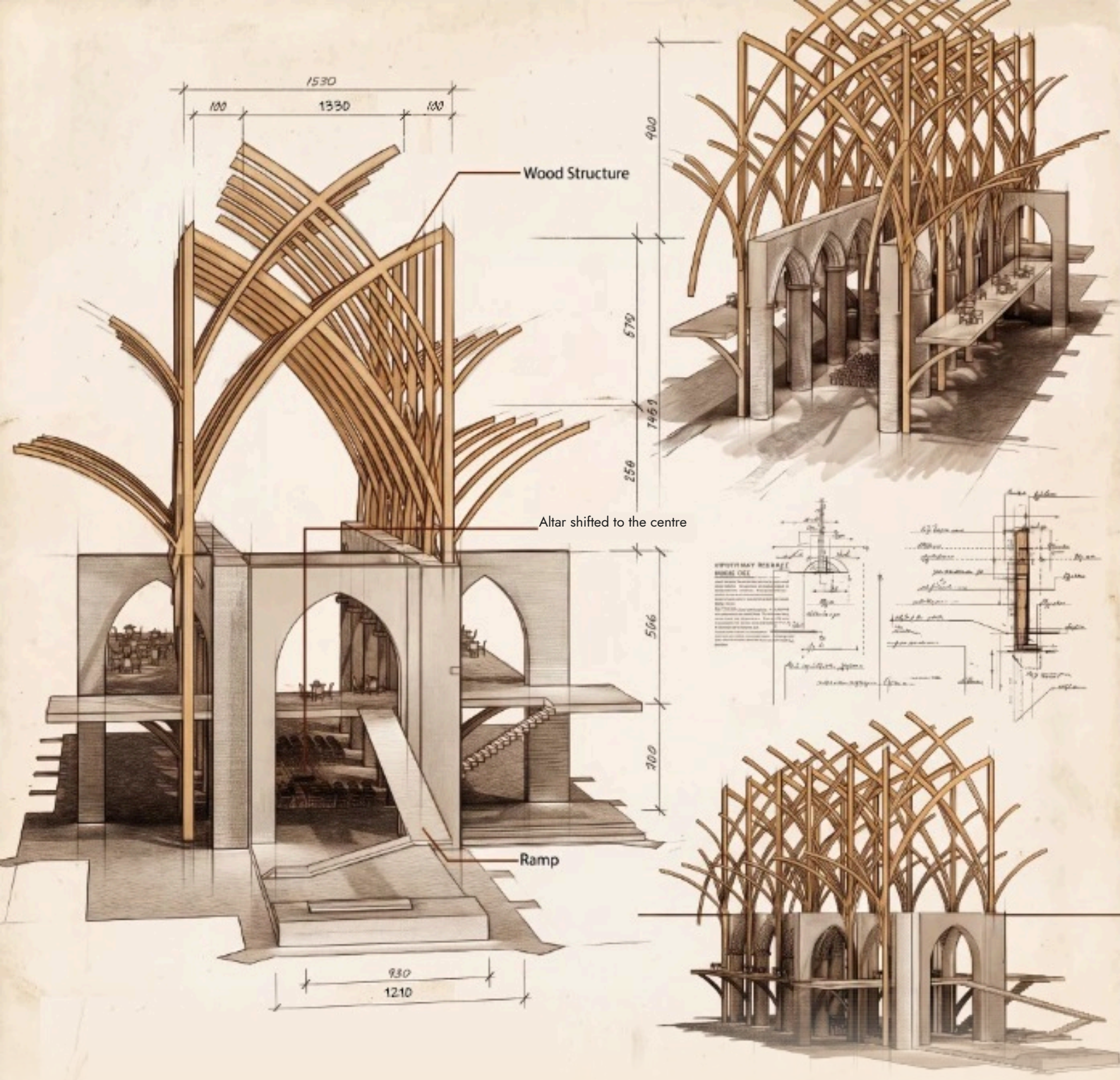
The structure stands entirely on its own. Old and new remain clearly readable: heavy brick and stone below, a light timber forest above. Because the historic fabric is not touched, the intervention is reversible and could be removed in the future, leaving the original church intact.

LIGHT

A band of glazing between the old walls and the new roof lets daylight into the nave. The branching ribs filter this light, casting changing patterns of light and shadow across the old walls, while the warm timber gives the ruin a welcoming atmosphere for worship, gathering and reading.

CONCLUSION

The project shows that a historic church can remain a sacred space while becoming an active part of everyday community life. New and old structures stand side by side, each readable on its own, together creating a place where the town can gather throughout the day, the week and the year.



LEFT

Axonometric section: timber "trees" rise through the nave and carry the roof; brackets support the library gallery, and a ramp connects both levels.

CENTRE RIGHT

Detail: every timber member shares a cross-section of 50 × 50 cm, built up from thin bonded layers of wood.

TOP RIGHT

The canopy over the nave: crossing ribs form a forest of pointed arches above the historic arcade.

BOTTOM RIGHT

Side view: the timber canopy rises freely above the historic walls, touching none of the old fabric.